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SEES:3540

Project 6

Justification of my Flow Map Design

I used three layers of symbology: nodes, flows, and a choropleth background, to help readers interpret both the magnitude and direction of interstate migration between 1887 and 1924. For the choropleth base map, I chose a sequential blue-to-red color scheme to represent net in-migration, with darker blues indicating higher in-migration and warmer reds indicating lower in-migration. Sequential schemes are recommended for ordered data because they allow viewers to intuitively read “more” versus “less” (Brewer, 2016). I kept the colors moderately muted so the background would not overpower the flow lines while still providing meaningful geographic context. State boundaries are outlined in a thin, neutral gray to maintain legibility without adding visual clutter.

The flow lines are scaled proportionally to the magnitude of migration between states. I used only three flow classes to prevent the map from becoming visually overwhelming. I also used curved lines, which help distinguish overlapping flows and better communicate directionality. The node symbols are simple gray circles placed at state centroids. I kept them uniform and unobtrusive so they would not compete with the flow lines or the choropleth; their purpose is simply to anchor the flows geographically. Because they do not add any additional data, keeping them super minimal supports overall map clarity. The title, *Interstate Migration Flowmap 1887–1924*, is straightforward and easy for any viewer to interpret no matter their skill level.

Interpretation of the Flow Patterns

The map shows that Midwestern states received the highest levels of in-migration during the 1887–1924 period, with states like Illinois, Ohio, or Iowa appearing in the darkest blue and receiving the thickest inbound flows with a few non-midwestern states like California or Texas sprinkled in. This pattern aligns with industrial expansion in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, when manufacturing centers attracted laborers from across the country. Several southern states, such as Mississippi and Alabama, appear as major sending regions. These states are shaded in lighter colors and show numerous outbound flows, suggesting broader historical patterns such as agricultural decline and limited economic opportunity.

The dominant flow directions are south-to-north and west-to-east, consistent with population movement toward industrializing urban centers. Many flows converge toward the Great Lakes region, while others move toward the Northeast. Western states show fewer and thinner flows, which could reflect lower population densities during this period.

The choropleth map reinforces the flow patterns: states with high in-migration also show thicker inbound flows, while states with low or negative net migration show predominantly outbound flows. The node placement at state centroids helps clarify the origins and destinations of flows without obscuring the choropleth.

